
Mapping Incoming Requests: Bipartite Network of St. Petersburg Literacy Committee 1885 Correspondence

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Abstract

From the 1870s, it was no longer clergy and officials who contacted the St. Petersburg Literacy Committee (hereafter the Committee), but teachers - the workers of public education - so wrote D. Protopopov, an active participant in the Committee's work and one of its earliest chroniclers (Protopopov, 1898). Analysis of the incoming correspondence register, however, points to a more complex interaction network and the roles of its principal correspondents. This paper examines the Committee's communication structure and shows how relations were organised. Bipartite network analysis allows not only to detect connections but also to describe their structure and density, tracing how these ties consolidated into a functioning network by 1885.

The analysis draws on the Committee's correspondence logs. Only five volumes - from 1885–1888 - survived in the Russian State Historical Archive. The 1885 journal, documenting 246 letters, was selected to construct the bipartite network (Zhurnal, RGIA f. 91, op. 3, d. 196). The network is constructed from two categories of data - sender types and request types - which formed the two node sets of the bipartite graph. Weighted edges reflect the frequency of each sender-request combination. The sender layer comprises 12 types grouped by sector - clergy, government departments, and others - while the request layer comprises 15 types, including book requests and financial transactions.

The findings invite a reassessment of Protopopov's narrative and historian Bradley's interpretation. Protopopov describes democratisation as a shift in the composition of correspondents from clergy toward teachers and zemstvo boards. This reading underpins Bradley's framing of a transition from government tutelage to public trust (Bradley, 2012). The graph both confirms and elaborates this picture: teachers emerge as the dominant sender type while clergy retain a secondary but persistent presence - measurable in correspondence volume rather than merely implied by tone. By 1885, the Committee had become a hub connecting clergy, officials, and teachers within a single correspondence network. It functioned simultaneously as a distributor of literacy resources and a broker between state institutions and civil society, secular and religious actors alike. Yet in the graph, private individuals form the second-largest node, connected to book donations, work submissions, and free book requests - a prominence that Bradley's account underemphasizes.

These results contribute to debates on voluntary associations and state authority in the Russian Empire. The Committee fostered what Bradley calls "horizontal linkages bypassing official channels" (Bradley, 2012). This tension, the network suggests, was embedded

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in everyday correspondence, visible in the coexistence of state institutions and individual teachers, as Bradley emphasises, but also of private and clerical actors. Few bodies besides the Committee bridged such a space. Methodologically, the study demonstrates that network analysis can uncover relational mechanisms (Ahnert & Ahnert, 2021) that Protopopov's narrative - a main source for Bradley - tends to obscure. Historical network analysis has rarely been applied to social relations in the Russian Empire (Ermakova & Nakishova, 2025), and this paper offers a model for its further use.

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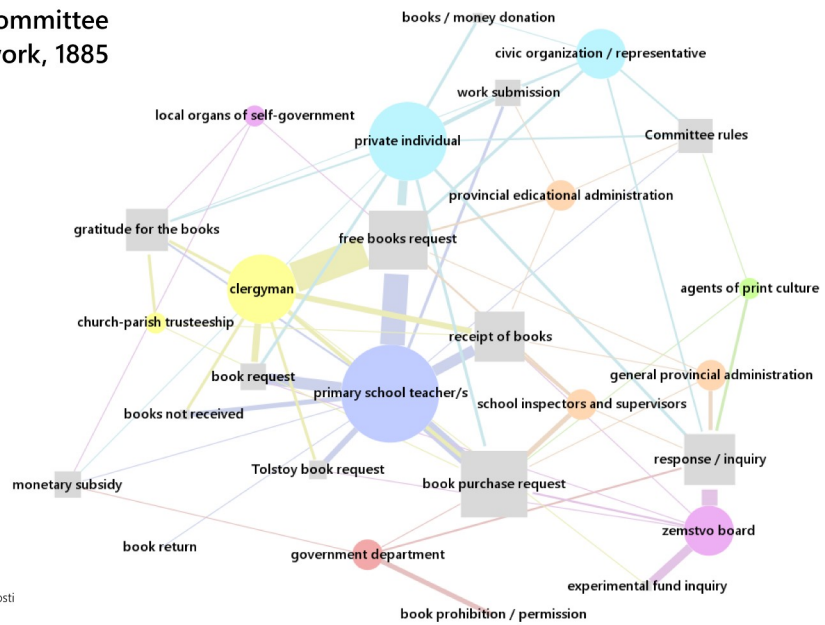
Zhurnal vkhodiashchim bumagam Komiteta gramotnosti, 1885–1889. Rossiiskii gosudarstvennyi istoricheskii archiv, f. 91, op. 3, d. 196–200. On microfilm.

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St. Petersburg Literacy Committee Incoming Requests Network, 1885

- request types
- sender types
- teachers
- religious actors
- private and civic actors
- self-government
- state supervisory bodies
- provincial administration
- print culture



Source:
Zhurnal vkhodiashchim bumagam Komiteta gramotnosti
RGIA f. 91, op. 3, d. 196